

AIOS · API RESEARCH

The APIs That Run the Audit

URL-only auditing, backlinks, citations & Web 2.0.

A source-checked survey of the APIs required to audit a website from nothing but its URL — performance, technical, SERP, local, backlinks, citations and AI/GEO — plus the backlink-data and Web 2.0 publishing APIs, their pricing, and Google's link-spam rules. Prices verified against live provider rates, July 2026.

URL-only

No user data to audit

Backlinks

Domain-only data

Citations

Listing accuracy

Web 2.0

Official-API publishing

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DATE

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PRICING BASIS

Live rates,
July 2026

01 SCOPE & METHOD

What we researched, and the one rule

The goal: find the APIs that let AIOS audit any website using **only its URL** — so the agency can measure a prospect before a single login is exchanged. Every candidate was checked for what it audits, how it authenticates, whether it needs the site owner's consent, and what it costs at ~15 clients.

10+

AUDIT APIS SURVEYED

2OWNER-AUTHORIZED
EXCEPTIONS (GSC, GA4)**3**WEB 2.0 PLATFORMS WITH
A REAL PUBLISH API**~\$29**/MO DATAFORSEO, ALL 15
CLIENTS**THE RULE THAT SHAPES EVERYTHING**

An audit source must take a **URL or a public crawl** and return data by observing the site from the outside — exactly as Google does. Anything that needs the owner to log in is an **optional enricher**, never a requirement.

Why it matters commercially

URL-only auditing means **zero onboarding friction**: run a Free-tier audit on any prospect's domain, show real findings, and convert. It's the engine of lead generation, not just a technical nicety.

How to read pricing: figures are approximate and checked against live provider rates in July 2026; confirm before purchase. **FREE** = free tier covers AIOS use · **PAID** = metered/prepaid.

02 THE CORE FINDING

URL-only vs owner-authorized

The central result of the research: almost every audit signal is available without the site owner. Only first-party analytics (Search Console, GA4) require consent — and AIOS treats those as optional.

SOURCE	AUDIT AREA	INPUT	URL-ONLY	COST
PageSpeed Insights / Lighthouse	Performance / CWV / SEO	URL	✓ URL	FREE
In-house crawler	Technical / on-page / crawl	URL	✓ URL	FREE
Serper.dev	SERP / ranks / features	Query	✓ URL	~\$0.001/search
DataForSEO (suite)	SERP / on-page / backlinks / local	URL/query	✓ URL	~\$29/mo-15
Google Places / Maps	Local / NAP	Name+geo	✓ URL	credit
Google Natural Language	Content / entities / E-E-A-T	Page text	✓ URL	FREE tier
Moz / Ahrefs / Majestic	Backlinks / authority	Domain	✓ URL	seat/credit
BrightLocal / Whitespark / Yext	Citations / listings	Business	✓ URL	PAID
Schema / Rich Results validator	Structured data	URL/HTML	✓ URL	FREE
Google Search Console	First-party clicks/position	OAuth	⚠ owner	FREE
Google Analytics 4	First-party traffic	OAuth	⚠ owner	FREE

Reading the two highlighted rows

GSC and GA4 are the **only** sources that touch owner data, and they add depth, not core coverage. The engine is built so a report never *depends* on them — connect them to enrich, skip them and the URL-only audit still stands.

03 DEEP DIVE · 1 OF 3

Performance, technical & SERP

PageSpeed Insights (Lighthouse) FREE

Performance, Core Web Vitals, SEO & accessibility from a URL. API-key auth, generous daily quota, no per-call charge. The primary performance source.

Endpoint: googleapis.com/pagespeedonline/v5

In-house crawler \$0

Runs on the agency's VPS — indexing, robots, sitemaps, redirects, broken links, headings, meta, canonicals. The backbone of the technical + actionable audit; why Free-tier audits cost nothing.

Serper.dev ~\$0.001

Fast Google SERP + rank tracking + SERP features (snippets, PAA, local pack, AI-overview presence). Prepaid credits, ~2,500 free. Free tier uses the free credits; Paid unlocks scheduled tracking.

Endpoint: google.serper.dev/search

DataForSEO suite ~\$29/mo

One vendor for SERP, On-Page, Lighthouse, Keywords, Backlinks & Business Data. Pay-as-you-go, no seats. The Paid-tier engine: rankings ~\$13.50 · audits ~\$7.20 · backlinks ~\$8 (15 clients).

OPEN DECISION — THE OFFICIAL RANKINGS SOURCE

Search Console shows an **average** position, not the real one. **serper.dev** is cheapest for good-enough ranks; **DataForSEO** is the most accurate. Both cost and pipeline depend on the pick — **confirm one before build**.

Backlink & citation data APIs

All backlink/citation data is **domain-only** — no owner login needed to see who links to a site or how it's listed. The finding: default to \$0 CSV import, switch to DataForSEO for automation.

BACKLINK DATA PROVIDERS

PROVIDER	RETURNS	COST (APPROX.)	USE IN PAID TIER
CSV import (existing seat)	Full backlink export	\$0 extra	Default — cheapest
DataForSEO Backlinks	Ref domains, anchors, DR-like, spam	~\$8/mo · 15 clients	Automated (rec.)
Moz Links API	Linking domains, DA/PA, spam	Free rows + paid plans	Alternative
Ahrefs API	Ref domains, DR, anchors	Subscription + credits	If seat exists
Majestic API	Trust/Citation Flow	Credits	Optional

LOCAL CITATION PROVIDERS

PROVIDER	RETURNS	URL-ONLY	USE IN PAID TIER
BrightLocal	Citation tracker, listing accuracy, rank grid		Standard
Whitespark	Citation finder, listing mgmt		Standard
Yext	Directory sync at scale		At scale
DataForSEO Business Data	Google Business + listing signals		Automated

Backlinks & citations are **Paid-tier** features (Free is audit-only). Within Paid, the agency can read a CSV from a seat it already pays for — ~5× cheaper and \$0 marginal — or automate weekly pulls via DataForSEO with new/lost-link alerts.

Web 2.0 publishing APIs & the rules

Automating Web 2.0 backlinks means publishing genuine articles to free hosted platforms via their **official APIs** — then verifying the link is live. Only some platforms offer a real publishing API; the rest stay draft-only.

PLATFORM	OFFICIAL PUBLISH API	AUTH	AUTO-POST	TOS RISK
WordPress.com	REST API	OAuth2	✓ yes	Low (genuine content)
Blogger	Blogger API v3 (Google)	OAuth2	✓ yes	Low
Tumblr	API v2	OAuth	✓ yes	Medium
Medium	Integration tokens deprecated	—	✗ draft-only	—
Dev.to / Hashnode / Ghost	REST API (modern alt.)	API key	✓ yes	Low
Weebly / Wix / others	Limited / none for this use	varies	✗ draft-only	—

THE PIPELINE

- 1 • Genuine article (multi-framework)**

on-topic, quality-gated
- 2 • Publish via official API**

WP.com / Blogger / Tumblr
- 3 • Verify live + indexable**

record URL + anchor
- 4 • Track & monitor**

Web 2.0 tab in Sheets

GOOGLE'S RULE — AND HOW WE STAY CLEAN

Google's **link-spam policy (SpamBrain)** penalizes automated, low-value links. AIOS answers with a **human quality gate**, genuinely useful articles, and **footprint diversification** (varied platforms, accounts, anchors, timing). This is branded, tiered link building — **not** a spam cannon.

06 RECOMMENDATION

The recommended API stack

Two tiers decide what a client gets: **Free is audit-only on free sources; Paid unlocks the full platform** on paid APIs. Within Paid, the agency chooses the cost lever — cheap CSV imports or full automation.

FREE · \$0 — AUDIT ONLY

Free sources only

PSI/Lighthouse, in-house crawler, serper.dev free credits, schema & security checks. A complete URL-only audit at no marginal cost — the client gets the audit and nothing else. The lead magnet.

PAID · FULL ACCESS

+ paid APIs, everything unlocked

Live rankings (serper.dev / DataForSEO), on-page, backlinks & business data, citations, content generation & publishing, and Web 2.0 — with a human approving each client-facing step. Cost scales with usage under a per-client cap.

PER-AUDIT COST — RECOMMENDED STACK

SOURCE	WHEN IT RUNS	APPROX. COST / AUDIT
PSI + crawler + schema	Every audit (both tiers)	\$0
serper.dev SERP checks	Free credits / Paid ranks	~\$0.01–0.05
DataForSEO (on-page + backlinks)	Paid tier only	~\$0.05–0.20
Claude (analysis + report)	Every audit	already owned
Typical URL-only audit (Free)	Free tier	~\$0

OPEN DECISIONS TO CLOSE BEFORE BUILD

- **Official rankings source** — serper.dev vs DataForSEO (cost + pipeline depend on it).
- **Paid-tier backlink source** — DataForSEO Backlinks (cheapest) vs Ahrefs/Moz seat / CSV import.
- **Web 2.0 platform accounts** — which platforms + accounts to provision for publishing.

THE ONE LINE TO REMEMBER

A full audit needs only a URL — Free covers it on free sources, Paid unlocks the rest of the platform on paid APIs.

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